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OPINION

What S.F. can learn from Uruguay's experiments with speed cameras

By **Matthew Fleischer**, Editorial Page Editor
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Speed cameras, pictured here aimed at U.S. Route 127 in New Miami, Ohio, in 2014, have been installed on the streets of San Francisco, and violators will be fined by the city for each offense.

Al Behrman/Associated Press

Recently, during an otherwise lovely walk in San Francisco, I was nearly run over by a car. Not once, not twice — three times.

Moments after leaving my home, an older driver blew through a stop sign, narrowly missing me in a crosswalk. A few minutes later, a driver sped through a red light, nearly T-boning a bus and wiping out a pack of pedestrians that included yours truly. Finally, a youthful moron driving illegally on Market Street nosed his way through a crowded crosswalk so he could go the wrong direction down a one-way stretch of Hyde Street.

I didn't particularly enjoy this troika of near-death experiences. But I'd come to expect it.

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San Francisco's driving culture is out of control — as evidenced by a recent [43-page report](#) from the San Francisco Civil Grand Jury, which determined that lawlessness has become the norm on our roads.

Help could be on the way this week when San Francisco finally begins issuing fines from its new system of speed cameras.

[Speed kills.](#) The fatality rate when a car strikes a pedestrian going 20 mph is 5%. It's 45% at 30 mph.

Nearly [100,000 people](#) received warnings from San Francisco speed cameras in May. That number tells all you need to know about our city's deadly driving culture.

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I would love to be optimistic that fines will calm things down. But I recently went to Uruguay, a South American country with some of the strictest traffic enforcement in the world. Just a few days there taught me how much more San Francisco needs to do to make the city safer.

I didn't realize Uruguay was a traffic tough guy when I booked my trip. But it didn't take me long to find out.

Before my rental car agent agreed to hand me the keys, she whipped out Google Translate to make sure one point was understood:

"Do not ... drive ... fast. *Tranquilo*. Slow. slow."

It was more of the same when I stopped nearby for lunch. "Be careful," the waiter warned. "Speeding tickets here are very expensive."

These warnings proved to be a theme. Practically everyone I met made sure I knew to go easy on the gas.

I was admittedly confused. I was wearing flip-flops and driving a Fiat the size of a lawn mower. Nothing about me screamed “Speed Racer.”

Did gringos like me have a bad reputation for being dangerous drivers?

No, it turned out gringos weren’t the problem.

Several years ago, traffic crashes and pedestrian deaths from speeding were out of control in Uruguay. So, officials installed a national network of speed cameras.

That system was no joke — hence the warnings. And it worked.

During my week in the country, I rarely saw anyone speeding. And I couldn't help but admire Uruguay's exceedingly well-executed plans.

Bright signs warned drivers well in advance of camera areas — giving no excuse for failing to slow down. The intent was clearly to change behavior, not to collect fines.

Camera zones didn't just last for an intersection or two — they sometimes went on for miles in highly populated areas.

Meanwhile, Uruguay didn't simply send tickets in the mail and call it a day. It used a variety of techniques to fundamentally change the country's toxic driving culture.

In high-danger areas, such as near schools or crowded beaches, speed limits were lowered — enforced by cameras — to as little as 15 mph. Meanwhile, crosswalks in these zones were mostly raised — forming massive speed bumps. This ensured that drivers couldn't absent-mindedly ignore speed limits and blow through crowded street crossings; paying attention was mandatory. These bumps also protected against speedy bad actors who might otherwise cover their license plates to avoid camera fines.

Traffic deaths dropped by 24% from record highs after the cameras went up. Still, that wasn't good enough. So, in 2016, Uruguay passed no-tolerance drunk driving laws. Fatalities dropped 20% more.

Even with an abundance of infrastructure, Uruguayan police still enforce traffic laws. On weekends, when the capital city of Montevideo empties and people go to nearby beach towns, busy roads are dotted with police cruisers.

The holistic interaction among infrastructure, technology and policing worked. Fatalities haven't been eliminated. But the high-traffic coastal areas I visited all felt like safe places to walk and bike. Kids roamed freely. Older people went on their morning walks. Tourists enjoyed cocktails in crowded areas without fear of becoming roadkill.

Uruguay's approach is a far cry from what I experienced living in Los Angeles County a few years ago, when red light cameras were installed to help stem deadly collisions in intersections.

Those cameras had little signage and often caught people off guard. Exorbitant fines barely differentiated between blowing a red light at

100 mph and a rolling right turn on red. And \$600-plus fines didn't go to municipal coffers. Privately run camera operators kept the dough.

Residents revolted. Judges ultimately found the camera fines to be unfair and unenforceable.

San Francisco's fledgling camera effort, meanwhile, might be too lax. Get caught travelling 100 mph over the posted speed limit by a camera, and the fine is \$500 — half that if you're low-income.

In my mind, anyone going that fast in a city as dense as San Francisco should lose their license.

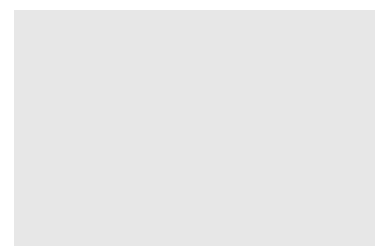
Uruguay, meanwhile, has found an enforcement sweet spot. Fines are high enough to inflict pain but not evoke populist outrage.

Last year, the country's president, Lacalle Pou, [made news](#) for riding his motorcycle 20 kilometers per hour over the posted limit in a camera zone. It cost him roughly \$200.

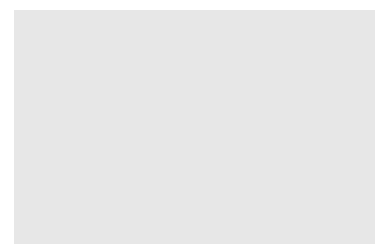
If my conversations there were any indication, Uruguayans far prefer strict enforcement to the carnage that came before it.

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When I dropped off my rental car at the end of my trip, the agent checked his computer to see if I had been busted. (Immigration officials won't let you leave the country with an unpaid speeding ticket.)

"Nothing!" he said, seemingly surprised.

"Everyone drives slowly here. It was great," I replied. "I live in California, where half the people think they're in a 'Fast and Furious' movie."

He laughed.

"It used to be like that here, too," he said. "Not anymore."

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San Francisco can get there. But it's going to take a complete culture change.

There's nothing sane or normal about the expectation of nearly being plowed over every time you leave the house.

Matthew Fleischer is the Chronicle's editorial page editor.



Matthew Fleischer

EDITORIAL PAGE EDITOR



Matthew Fleischer oversees the Chronicle's Opinion section, which includes unsigned editorials, political endorsements, Open Forum submissions, letters to the editor, political cartoons and the work of staff and freelance Opinion columnists.

He came to the paper from the L.A. Times, where he spent six years as senior digital editor of the Pulitzer-winning Opinion team. Prior to that, Matthew was a staff writer for LA Weekly and an investigative reporter for the watchdog site Witness L.A., where his stories helped expose the abuse and corruption in the Los Angeles Sheriff's Department that led to the convictions of Sheriff Lee Baca and Undersheriff Paul Tanaka for obstruction of justice.

His work has been honored by the Overseas Press Club Foundation, Investigative Reporters and Editors, PEN Center USA and Best of the West. His Chronicle Opinion team has won consecutive National Headliner Awards.

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The report, which details how transit cuts could make traffic apocalyptic, was put out by a nonprofit think tank that has endorsed both upcoming transit measures in the November election.

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